

(Im)politeness in Conflict Talks and Mediatized Identity Construction in Nigeria's 10th Senate

Richard Oliseyenum Maledo & Efeturi Lawrence Divramredje
Department of English and Literary Studies, Delta State University, Abraka

Abstract

This study examines how politeness and impoliteness strategies in conflict talk shape the construction of mediatized identities in Nigeria's 10th Senate. Given the paucity of studies on parliamentary discourse, this paper explores how senators deploy linguistic resources to negotiate power, legitimacy, and public identity in a highly visible parliamentary environment. Drawing on politeness and impoliteness theories, it adopts a pragmatic approach to analyse selected excerpts from plenary debates of Nigeria's 10th Senate. Data are drawn from Hansard records, National Assembly Service Television broadcasts, and widely circulated digital media clips, reflecting the extension of parliamentary discourse beyond the chamber into the public sphere. The analysis reveals that conflict talk is not merely disruptive but strategically organised. Senators combine politeness and impoliteness strategies, such as mitigation, accusation, sarcasm, and mock politeness, to manage face, regulate participation, and assert ideological positions. These strategies also serve as resources for constructing mediatized political identities, as speakers orient their contributions to both institutional and public audiences.

Keywords: Politeness, Impoliteness, Conflict Talks, Parliamentary Discourse, Mediatized Identity Construction

Introduction

Parliamentary discourse is conventionally characterised as both adversarial and institutionally regulated. While disagreement and contestation are inherent features of legislative interaction, procedural norms constrain these exchanges by demanding decorum, respect, and adherence to institutional hierarchy (Ilie, 2015). Legislative chambers are therefore structured environments in which confrontation is not only expected but also carefully managed through linguistic and procedural conventions. Within such settings, speakers must continually negotiate the tension between expressing opposition and maintaining institutional order. In contemporary Nigeria, however, the communicative dynamics of parliamentary discourse have changed significantly. Through live broadcasts, real-time reporting, and the widespread circulation of debate excerpts across digital platforms, Senate proceedings are no longer confined to the chamber but are increasingly mediatized, extending into broader public spheres (Wodak, 2011). This shift has redefined legislative communication, transforming it from a primarily institutional activity into a public and performative practice subject to continuous scrutiny and reinterpretation.

This mediatized environment has important implications for the nature and function of conflict talks in parliamentary discourse. Rather than functioning solely as interactional disagreement among co-present participants, conflict talks now serve as performative resources through which political actors negotiate visibility, legitimacy, and identity before multiple audiences. Linguistic choices are therefore oriented not only to

fellow legislators but also to constituents, media audiences, and the wider public. As a result, conflictual exchanges may be strategically shaped not only to challenge opposing positions but also to construct public identities, such as defenders of justice, critics of authority, or representatives of marginalised interests. Although existing scholarship has examined politeness through the work of Penelope Brown and Stephen Levinson (1987), as well as impoliteness in Jonathan Culpeper (2011) and adversarial discourse in Harris (2001), relatively limited attention has been paid to how these interactional strategies function within mediatised African legislative contexts. Much of the existing literature remains grounded in Western parliamentary systems, leaving a gap in understanding how politeness, impoliteness, and conflict talks operate within the socio-political and cultural realities of African democracies. In the Nigerian context, where political discourse is shaped by regional identity, power relations, and heightened media visibility, the need for such analysis becomes particularly pressing.

Furthermore, while studies have explored conflict in discourse as an interactional phenomenon, fewer have examined how conflict talks intersect with identity construction in highly visible institutional settings. The Nigerian 10th Senate provides a compelling site for such investigation, given its diverse membership, politically charged debates, and strong mediatisation through television and digital media platforms. The interactions within this chamber offer valuable insight into how language functions simultaneously as a tool for institutional negotiation and as a resource for public performance. This study therefore investigates how senators in Nigeria's 10th Senate deploy linguistic resources to negotiate power, manage face, and construct mediatised political identities within an increasingly public and performative communicative environment. By integrating politeness theory, impoliteness theory, and facework within the broader framework of conflict talks, the study contributes to a deeper understanding of how parliamentary discourse operates as both an institutional and mediatised communicative practice.

The Nigerian 10th Senate and Mediatised Discourse

The Nigerian Senate occupies a central position in the country's democratic governance as the upper chamber of the National Assembly. It performs key constitutional functions, including lawmaking, oversight of executive activities, confirmation of public appointments, and representation of the federating units within the federal structure. As such, the Senate serves as an important institutional space for policy deliberation, democratic accountability, and the negotiation of national interests (Omotola, 2010). Parliamentary interaction within the Senate is governed by established procedural rules, particularly the Standing Orders, which regulate participation, turn-taking, and acceptable forms of address. Senators are required to channel their contributions through the presiding officer and to employ institutionalised expressions such as "Distinguished Senator" and "Mr President, Sir." These conventions are designed to maintain decorum, reinforce hierarchy, and preserve the institutional dignity of legislative proceedings. However, despite these formal constraints, debates within the Senate often reflect broader socio-political tensions, resulting in moments of disagreement, resistance, and confrontation.

The Nigerian Senate has historically functioned not only as a legislative forum but also as a site of political contestation. Legislative debates frequently extend beyond policy

discussion to include struggles over authority, legitimacy, and ideological positioning. This dynamic is consistent with observations that political discourse in Nigeria often involves strategic deployment of confrontational and evaluative language as participants seek to assert dominance, defend positions, or challenge opponents (Odebunmi & Ayoola, 2017). Consequently, conflict talks emerge as an inherent and functional aspect of parliamentary communication rather than a deviation from institutional norms. Moreover, the heightened visibility of Senate proceedings has intensified the rhetorical nature of parliamentary communication. Statements made during debates are rapidly disseminated across media platforms, transforming routine legislative exchanges into widely circulated public discourse. In this context, senators frequently orient their contributions toward dual audiences, addressing both colleagues within the chamber and external publics. This dual orientation often results in the use of expressive, evaluative, and sometimes confrontational language, including accusations, interruptions, sarcasm, and rhetorical challenges.

The contemporary Senate operates within an increasingly mediated environment, which brings about mediated identity construction. The increasing accessibility of Senate proceedings through television broadcasts and digital media has amplified public engagement with legislative discourse. Clips of parliamentary exchanges often circulate widely on social media, where they are interpreted, debated, and sometimes recontextualised. This means that the identities constructed within the Senate are not confined to institutional interpretation but are continuously reshaped through public discourse. Furthermore, mediation interacts with broader socio-political dynamics such as party affiliation, regional identity, gender, and public expectation. Senators may strategically align their discourse with these factors to strengthen their public image and political relevance. Plenary proceedings are broadcast live through official channels such as the National Assembly Service Television and are widely reported by news media and circulated across digital platforms. This development has transformed legislative discourse into a public communicative event that extends beyond the chamber. Senators are therefore not only engaged in institutional deliberation but are also performing before a wider audience that includes constituents, party supporters, journalists, and the general public. As Wodak (2011) observes, mediation reconfigures political discourse into a performative space where language is used strategically to construct identity and influence public perception.

This mediated dynamic is particularly evident in Nigeria's 10th Senate, inaugurated on 13 June 2023. The chamber is composed of a politically diverse group of actors, including experienced politicians, former governors, technocrats, activists, and first-time legislators. These participants bring varied communicative styles and rhetorical resources into parliamentary interaction. Senior members often draw on institutional authority and experience, while newer members may adopt assertive or strategic forms of participation to establish visibility and legitimacy within the chamber. Such diversity contributes to the emergence of conflict talks as participants negotiate competing interests, ideological positions, and representational claims. Within this environment, conflict talks become central to the functioning of parliamentary discourse. They enable senators to challenge policies, question authority, assert ideological positions, and represent the interests of their constituencies. At the same time, such interactions involve

complex pragmatic processes, as speakers must balance confrontation with the demands of institutional decorum. This balance is achieved through the strategic use of politeness and impoliteness resources, which allow participants to negotiate face, maintain legitimacy, and manage interactional tension. The 10th Senate therefore provides a rich context for examining how conflict talks operate within a mediated legislative environment. It offers insight into how language is used not only to deliberate policy but also to construct identity, negotiate power, and perform accountability in contemporary Nigerian political discourse.

Conflict Talks

Conflict talks refer to the use of language in interactional contexts where speakers challenge, oppose, resist, undermine, or contest the position, authority, identity, or projected face of other participants. They represent the observable, moment-to-moment realisation of disagreement in discourse, where opposition becomes linguistically and interactionally visible. Conflict talks may manifest in direct contradiction, accusation, interruption, dismissal, sarcasm, rhetorical challenge, hostile questioning, or procedural resistance. Importantly, conflict talks are not simply a breakdown of communication; rather, they are socially meaningful and often strategic forms of interaction through which speakers negotiate difference, power, and alignment (Tannen, 1990; Gruber, 1996; Hutchby, 1996).

A central assumption in the study of conflict talk is that disagreement is not random but sequentially organised. Conflict emerges through interactional development across turns: one speaker advances a claim, another contests it, a third may intensify or redirect it, and the exchange may then be escalated, mitigated, or repaired. For this reason, conflict talks must be analysed not as isolated hostile utterances but as unfolding processes shaped by turn-taking, adjacency pairs, response patterns, and contextual expectations. Tannen (1990), for instance, demonstrates that opposition may function as a preferred communicative style in certain contexts, while Hutchby (1996) shows that conflict is often constructed through argumentative moves that challenge prior assumptions or speaker authority.

Conflict talks perform multiple communicative functions. At one level, they express disagreement and oppositional stance-taking. At another, they signal ideological distance, defend self-positioning, resist dominance, and expose inconsistency in the speech or conduct of others. In institutional contexts, particularly legislative settings, conflict talks also perform accountability by enabling participants to question decisions, policies, procedures, and authority structures. Consequently, conflict should not be viewed purely as a negative phenomenon. In democratic and deliberative environments, it is often a necessary condition for scrutiny, debate, and the testing of competing viewpoints. It should be noted that conflict talks are intrinsically tied to face threat. Acts such as interruption, accusation, ridicule, and dismissal challenge the interlocutor's social image, interactional rights, and public credibility. This is why conflict talks are closely linked to politeness, impoliteness, and facework. A disagreement may be carefully mitigated through politeness strategies or intensified through impoliteness strategies. Thus, the study of conflict talks must attend not only to the presence of opposition but

also to how such opposition is linguistically framed, intensified, softened, or managed within interaction.

(Im)politeness in Discourse

The term (Im)politeness consists of two lexical items in pragmatics and discourse studies: politeness and impoliteness. Politeness refers to the linguistic and social strategies speakers use to manage interpersonal relations, maintain mutual respect, and reduce the possibility of offence during interaction (Brown & Levinson, 1987; Watts, 2003), while Impoliteness refers to the use of linguistic strategies that are designed to attack face, cause offence, or challenge the social standing of an interlocutor within interaction. Both terms are socially significant aspects of communication through which speakers negotiate distance, solidarity, power, deference, and appropriateness. Because many communicative acts such as criticism, disagreement, accusation, correction, and interruption potentially create tension, they become an important means of regulating interaction and preserving social order.

One of the foundational ideas behind politeness is Goffman's (1967) notion of face, which refers to the public self-image individuals seek to maintain in interaction. Goffman argues that social encounters are organised around the mutual maintenance of face, and that participants routinely engage in facework to avoid embarrassment, humiliation, or social disruption. From this perspective, politeness may be seen as one of the means through which speakers attend to the face needs of others and sustain the smooth flow of interaction. In pragmatics, Lakoff (1973) is among the earliest scholars to describe politeness systematically, presenting it as a set of rules intended to reduce friction in communication. Leech (1983) also linked politeness to the maintenance of social harmony, arguing that speakers often shape utterances in ways that minimise impolite meanings and maximise polite ones. However, the most influential account remains Brown and Levinson's (1987) theory, which places face at the centre of interaction. They distinguish between positive face, the desire to be approved of and appreciated, and negative face, the desire for autonomy and freedom from imposition. Communicative acts that threaten these wants are described as face-threatening acts, and speakers often employ politeness strategies to mitigate them. Brown and Levinson (1987) identify four broad strategic options available to speakers in handling potentially face-threatening acts. A speaker may go bald on record, employ positive politeness, employ negative politeness, or go off record. These strategies show that politeness is not a fixed property of language, but a flexible set of communicative choices shaped by context, speaker goals, and social relations.

The systematic study of impoliteness is most prominently associated with the work of Jonathan Culpeper (1996, 2011), who reconceptualises impoliteness as a functional and context-dependent phenomenon rather than a breakdown of communicative norms. Culpeper argues that speakers may deliberately employ impoliteness strategies to damage the addressee's face, challenge authority, express ideological opposition, or achieve interactional control. This perspective is especially relevant in institutional settings where conflict is expected and often strategically enacted. Culpeper identifies several key impoliteness strategies that provide a useful analytical framework for examining adversarial discourse. Bald-on-record impoliteness involves direct and unmitigated face

attack, often realised through explicit accusations or commands. Positive impoliteness seeks to damage the addressee's positive face by undermining their need for approval, for example through ridicule, dismissal, or questioning competence. Negative impoliteness, on the other hand, targets the addressee's desire for autonomy by imposing constraints, issuing directives, or limiting participation. Mock politeness occurs when superficially polite expressions are used sarcastically to convey criticism or contempt, while withholding politeness involves the absence of expected courtesy, thereby producing offence through omission rather than explicit attack. Importantly, impoliteness in institutional discourse is not necessarily disorderly or inappropriate. In contexts such as parliamentary debate, it often serves specific rhetorical and ideological functions. Speakers may deploy impoliteness to expose perceived injustice, challenge institutional authority, delegitimise opposing arguments, or assert strong political positioning. As such, impoliteness becomes a resource for contestation rather than a violation of communicative norms.

In the Nigerian context, impoliteness is further shaped by socio-political and cultural dynamics, including hierarchy, seniority, regional identity, and public accountability. Within the Senate, where interaction is both regulated and adversarial, impoliteness strategies frequently coexist with formal politeness markers. A speaker may maintain institutional decorum through address forms such as "Distinguished Senator" while simultaneously delivering sharp criticism, accusation, or dismissal. This coexistence reflects the complex nature of parliamentary discourse, where respect and confrontation are continuously negotiated.

Theoretical Framework

This study adopts an integrated theoretical framework that combines Goffman's (1967) concept of face and facework, Brown and Levinson's (1987) politeness theory, and Culpeper's (1996, 2011) impoliteness framework. These complementary perspectives provide a robust analytical foundation for examining how language is used to manage interpersonal relations, negotiate authority, and structure conflict talks within a mediated parliamentary environment.

Goffman's (1967) notion of face serves as the conceptual starting point for this analysis. Face refers to the positive social value that individuals claim for themselves in interaction, while facework encompasses the strategies employed to maintain, defend, or repair that value. In parliamentary discourse, however, face extends beyond the individual speaker to include institutional and ideological dimensions. As Ilie (2015) observes, participants in legislative debates are not only concerned with personal credibility but also with the protection of institutional legitimacy and political positioning. Within Nigeria's 10th Senate, conflict talks therefore involve complex layers of face negotiation, where speakers simultaneously defend personal reputation, align with group interests, and uphold or challenge the authority of the institution.

Building on this foundation, Brown and Levinson's (1987) politeness theory provides a systematic account of how speakers mitigate face-threatening acts in interaction. The theory distinguishes between positive face, which relates to the desire for approval and social acceptance, and negative face, which concerns the desire for autonomy and freedom from imposition. Because conflict talks inherently involve

disagreement, criticism, and opposition, they frequently generate threats to both dimensions of face. Speakers therefore employ a range of politeness strategies to manage these threats. In the Nigerian Senate, institutionalised address forms such as “Distinguished Senator” and “Mr President, Sir” function as negative politeness strategies by encoding deference and recognising hierarchical authority (Agbara, 2018). At the same time, inclusive pronouns, alignment markers, and appeals to shared responsibility may serve as positive politeness strategies that construct solidarity even in the midst of disagreement. Importantly, these strategies do not eliminate conflict; rather, they regulate how conflict is expressed, allowing confrontation to occur within acceptable institutional boundaries.

While politeness theory explains how speakers mitigate face threat, it does not fully account for instances where speakers deliberately intensify confrontation. Culpeper’s (1996, 2011) impoliteness framework addresses this limitation by conceptualising impoliteness as the strategic use of language to attack face and cause offence. His typology—which includes bald-on-record impoliteness, positive impoliteness, negative impoliteness, mock politeness, and withholding politeness—provides a detailed model for analysing adversarial interaction in institutional contexts. In parliamentary discourse, such strategies are not merely accidental breaches of decorum but often serve specific rhetorical and ideological functions. As observed in studies of political communication (Mugari, 2019; Nartey, 2018), impoliteness may be used to challenge credibility, undermine authority, enforce procedural control, or dramatise opposition during debate.

Taken together, these frameworks position parliamentary discourse along a dynamic politeness–impoliteness continuum, where speakers continuously balance mitigation and confrontation. This continuum is particularly significant in a mediatised environment such as Nigeria’s 10th Senate, where utterances are oriented not only towards co-present participants but also towards wider public audiences. Within this context, politeness and impoliteness strategies extend beyond immediate interactional goals to become resources for mediatised identity construction. Speakers may deploy politeness to project respectability and institutional alignment, or use impoliteness to construct identities as critics, reformists, or defenders of public interest. The integrated framework adopted in this study therefore enables a comprehensive analysis of how conflict talks function simultaneously as interactional practices, institutional processes, and performative acts of identity construction.

For the purpose of analysis, this study adopts specific politeness and impoliteness strategies as analytical categories. Drawing on the model of Penelope Brown and Stephen Levinson (1987), politeness strategies are identified as bald-on-record, positive politeness, negative politeness, and off-record strategies, while the framework of Jonathan Culpeper (1996, 2011) provides categories such as bald-on-record impoliteness, positive impoliteness, negative impoliteness, mock politeness, and withholding politeness. These categories are applied flexibly to account for the layered and context-dependent nature of parliamentary discourse, where mitigation and confrontation often co-occur within the same interaction.

Review of Related Literature

Scholarly engagement with parliamentary discourse has consistently highlighted its dual character as both adversarial and institutionally regulated. Early work in this area shows that legislative interaction is inherently structured around disagreement, opposition, and contestation, yet constrained by procedural norms that maintain order and decorum. For instance, Ilie (2015) observes that parliamentary discourse is not simply argumentative but ritualised, in the sense that confrontation is expected, recurrent, and governed by institutional conventions. In this regard, conflict is not treated as a breakdown of communication but as a functional component of democratic deliberation. Closely related to this position are studies that examine the organisation of conflict in interaction. Scholars such as Tannen (1990) and Hutchby (1996). While Tannen (1990) demonstrates that opposition may function as a communicative style in certain contexts, Hutchby (1996) shows that conflict talk is often constructed through strategic argumentative moves that challenge assumptions, authority, or prior contributions. These perspectives are particularly relevant to parliamentary settings, where speakers are expected to contest positions while remaining within institutional boundaries.

Within political discourse specifically, the role of adversarial communication has been further elaborated. Harris (2001) extends politeness theory to parliamentary interaction by demonstrating that impoliteness is not necessarily a violation of norms but may be strategically deployed to achieve rhetorical goals. Similarly, Bull and Wells (2012) describe political debate as adversarial discourse in which speakers deliberately engage in opposition to persuade, challenge, and position themselves ideologically. These studies collectively suggest that confrontation is not only expected in political settings but is also a resource through which power and legitimacy are negotiated. However, much of this scholarship has been developed within Western parliamentary contexts, thereby leaving a gap in understanding how similar interactional dynamics operate within African legislative environments. In response to this gap, recent studies have begun to explore the nature of political discourse in African settings. For example, Nartey (2018) examines impoliteness in parliamentary debate and shows that speakers frequently employ face-threatening strategies such as interruption, accusation, and sarcasm in order to assert dominance and challenge opposing viewpoints. In a related study, Mugari (2019) demonstrates that politeness and impoliteness are often intertwined in political discourse, with speakers strategically combining both in order to maintain institutional form while advancing strong criticism.

In the Nigerian context, the work of Odebunmi and Ayoola (2017) provides further insight into the culturally grounded nature of political impoliteness. Their study reveals that impoliteness in Nigerian political discourse is shaped by factors such as power relations, social hierarchy, and contextual expectations. This suggests that impoliteness is not merely a linguistic phenomenon but one that is deeply embedded in socio-political realities. Similarly, Agbara (2018) examines politeness strategies in Nigerian parliamentary discourse and shows that formal address forms and expressions of deference are central to maintaining institutional decorum, even in the midst of disagreement. Despite these important contributions, there remains a notable gap in the literature. While existing studies have examined politeness, impoliteness, and adversarial discourse separately, fewer have integrated these perspectives within the framework of

conflict talks in a mediatised parliamentary environment. In addition, limited attention has been given to how these interactional strategies contribute to the construction of political identity, particularly in African legislative contexts where discourse is increasingly shaped by media visibility and public engagement.

Given the rise of live broadcasts, digital circulation, and social media commentary, parliamentary discourse in Nigeria's 10th Senate now operates within a highly mediatised space. Utterances produced within the chamber are no longer confined to institutional interpretation but are rapidly disseminated and reinterpreted by wider audiences. This development introduces a performative dimension to legislative communication, where speakers design their contributions not only to influence colleagues but also to construct public identities. However, the relationship between conflict talk, politeness, impoliteness, and mediatised identity construction remains underexplored in existing research. It is within this gap that the present study is situated. By examining how senators in Nigeria's 10th Senate deploy politeness and impoliteness strategies within conflict talks, this study extends existing scholarship beyond Western contexts and contributes to a deeper understanding of how language functions simultaneously as a tool of interaction, contestation, and identity performance in a contemporary African parliamentary setting.

Methodology

The data for this study are drawn from plenary debates of Nigeria's 10th Senate (2023-2025), sourced from official Hansard records, National Assembly Service Television (NASS TV) broadcasts, and widely circulated digital media clips. From a broader corpus of conflict talks identified across Senate proceedings, ten representative excerpts were purposively selected based on their relevance to politeness and impoliteness strategies, their interactional richness, and their recurrence within the dataset. The selection prioritises episodes that clearly illustrate how senators negotiate disagreement, authority, and identity through language within institutional constraints. Our data are coded as DATA I – DATA X for ease of identification and analysis. The analysis focuses on salient linguistic features such as modality, evaluative lexis, metaphor, pronoun use, directive expressions, and irony. These features serve as observable discourse resources through which politeness and impoliteness strategies are realised in interaction.

Data Presentation and Analysis

DATA I: Senator Akpoti-Uduaghan: Mr President, Sir, I must be heard on this matter.

Senator Akpabio: Distinguished Senator, you are out of order.

This exchange illustrates how ritual politeness in parliamentary discourse does not eliminate confrontation but rather frames and regulates it. The address form "Mr President, Sir" is a highly conventionalised negative politeness marker. It acknowledges institutional hierarchy, shows deference, and signals that the speaker is aware of the procedural order governing Senate interaction. In Brown and Levinson's terms, it attends to the negative face of the presiding officer by recognising his authority and reducing the

appearance of direct imposition. However, the politeness of the address is immediately complicated by the second part of the utterance, “I must be heard on this matter.” The modal auxiliary, “must”, is particularly significant here. Unlike a softened request such as “I would like to be heard” or “may I be heard,” “must” expresses necessity and insistence. It therefore increases the force of the utterance and transforms it from a respectful appeal into a challenge to the Senate President’s power over turn allocation.

This creates a tension at the heart of parliamentary discourse. On the surface, the speaker is complying with decorum through formal address, yet at the substantive level she is contesting the terms of participation. The utterance thus performs a double move: it preserves institutional respect while simultaneously asserting discursive entitlement. From a Goffmanian perspective, this is an act of facework in which the speaker attempts to preserve her own face as a legitimate participant whose contribution cannot be denied, while also acknowledging the procedural face of the institution.

Akpabio’s response mirrors this duality. The address “Distinguished Senator” maintains ritual politeness and keeps the interaction recognisably parliamentary. Yet the declarative “you are out of order” is a formal procedural sanction. It functions as a public restriction of the speaker’s interactional rights and therefore constitutes negative impoliteness in Culpeper’s framework, since it constrains the addressee’s freedom to continue speaking. More importantly, the ruling does not merely regulate talk; it performs authority. Akpabio is not just disagreeing with the speaker but reaffirming the institutional hierarchy in which the chair has the power to decide who speaks, when, and under what conditions. At a mediatised level, both speakers are also constructing identities before a public audience. Akpoti-Uduaghan emerges as assertive, resistant, and unwilling to be procedurally silenced, while Akpabio is projected as the custodian of order and institutional authority. The exchange is therefore not only about turn-taking but also about how political roles are publicly performed.

DATA II: Senator Onowakpo-Thomas: With due respect, Senator Lalong, Warri is not your constituency.

Senator Lalong: Distinguished Senator, injustice anywhere concerns all of us.

This exchange reveals how politeness can be used not simply to soften disagreement but to restructure the terms of legitimacy within debate. Onowakpo-Thomas begins with “With due respect,” a conventional mitigating expression that signals awareness of the face-threatening nature of the utterance to follow. At the surface level, this functions as a negative politeness marker, as it anticipates possible offence and attempts to reduce the force of the challenge. However, the mitigating effect is immediately overridden by the directness of the subsequent claim, “Warri is not your constituency,” which performs a clear boundary-setting move and questions the addressee’s representational legitimacy. The utterance therefore operates as a legitimacy challenge. It suggests that political authority in this context should be tied to constituency ownership, local representation, and immediate stake. In doing so, it threatens Lalong’s positive face by implying that his intervention lacks proper grounding in representational entitlement. The absence of further hedging after the initial polite preface intensifies this effect, as the speaker moves

swiftly from mitigation to direct territorial delimitation. Lalong's reply is strategically expansive. The address "Distinguished Senator" maintains formal decorum, but the main pragmatic work lies in the clause "injustice anywhere concerns all of us." The inclusive pronoun "all of us" functions as a strong positive politeness strategy, constructing shared moral membership and collective responsibility. Rather than accept the territorial framing proposed by Onowakpo-Thomas, Lalong reframes the issue in ethical and universal terms, shifting the basis of legitimacy from constituency ownership to national moral obligation.

This response is pragmatically powerful because it redefines the grounds of participation in the debate. The implication is that one does not require territorial affiliation to speak against injustice. In Goffman's terms, this constitutes face restoration through reframing, as the speaker does not defend himself within the imposed boundaries but instead reconstructs the interactional frame itself. In the broader context of mediated parliamentary discourse, this exchange also contributes to identity construction. Onowakpo-Thomas emerges as a defender of representational specificity and constituency-based authority, while Lalong projects an identity grounded in moral universality and collective responsibility. This illustrates how conflict talk functions not only as opposition but also as a resource for performing political identity before both institutional and public audiences.

DATA III: Senator Ndume: This report is empty. We cannot continue to act rubber stamps.

Senator Adeola: Distinguished Senator, mind your language.

Ndume's intervention combines collective alignment with institutional delegitimisation. The first clause, "This report is empty," is striking for its lexical absolutism. The adjective "empty" is not a mild critique such as weak, incomplete, or problematic. It performs a near-total rejection of substantive value. The utterance therefore attacks the competence and seriousness of the report's producers, and by extension the committee and institutional processes behind it. This is a strong positive face-threatening act because it denies worth, labour, and intellectual substance. The second clause, "We cannot continue to act rubber stamps," intensifies the criticism. The inclusive pronoun "we" is important. At one level, it is a positive politeness strategy because it aligns the speaker with the wider Senate rather than isolating blame onto one individual. At another level, it broadens the scope of the criticism from the report itself to the collective institution. The metaphor "rubber stamps" is especially powerful in political discourse because it suggests passivity, executive capture, and absence of genuine scrutiny. By invoking it, Ndume implies that the Senate is failing in its constitutional role as a deliberative and oversight body.

This metaphor therefore does more than criticise a report. It threatens the institutional face of the Senate as an independent legislative chamber. From a Goffmanian perspective, the utterance destabilises the public self-image of the chamber by presenting it as compliant rather than critical. It also has mediated resonance, since "rubber stamp" is a widely recognisable phrase in public political commentary and is likely to circulate effectively beyond the chamber. Adeola's response, "Distinguished Senator, mind your language," again reflects the dual structure of parliamentary conflict. The address form

preserves decorum, but the directive itself is a clear act of discursive regulation. It does not answer the substantive criticism. Instead, it shifts the interaction from content to mode of expression. In Culpeper's terms, the directive is negative impoliteness because it attempts to constrain how the addressee may speak. It is also a form of institutional facework because it tries to repair reputational damage by disciplining the language through which that damage is being produced.

The exchange shows that in Senate discourse, criticism of institutional failure often provokes metalinguistic responses. Rather than rebutting the allegation directly, defenders of the institution may contest the propriety of the language used. This makes the struggle not only about political substance but also about who gets to define the boundaries of acceptable parliamentary criticism.

DATA IV: Senator Akpoti-Uduaghan: It is hypocrisy to lecture Nigerians while skipping committee meetings.

Senator Goje: Watch your tongue. You have not been here long enough.

This exchange is one of the clearest illustrations of bald-on-record impoliteness in the dataset. Akpoti-Uduaghan's utterance contains no meaningful mitigation. The lexical item "hypocrisy" is a direct moral accusation, and it is important precisely because it goes beyond descriptive criticism. To accuse someone of hypocrisy is not merely to say they are inconsistent; it is to claim that there is a contradiction between their public moral stance and their actual conduct. This is a severe attack on positive face because it challenges sincerity, integrity, and moral credibility. The structure of the utterance intensifies the accusation through contrast. The verb "lecture" projects authority, moral superiority, and public instruction. The phrase "while skipping committee meetings" undermines that authority by pairing it with institutional irresponsibility. The conflict here is therefore not only interpersonal but moral-institutional. The speaker is arguing that a person who fails in basic legislative duty is not entitled to occupy the moral position of one who instructs others. Pragmatically, this is a delegitimising move.

Goje's response is equally forceful, though it shifts the terrain of conflict. The imperative "Watch your tongue" is a direct regulatory command that attempts to control the speaker's manner of expression rather than rebut the accusation itself. In Culpeper's terms, this is negative impoliteness because it imposes on the addressee's communicative freedom. The second clause, "You have not been here long enough," introduces seniority and institutional tenure as the criterion for legitimate speech. This is important because it redefines the dispute: instead of answering the moral accusation, Goje questions the critic's authority to make it.

From a Goffmanian perspective, this is an attempt at face repair through hierarchical repositioning. Goje does not restore face by denying the allegation directly; he restores it by casting the speaker as institutionally junior and therefore less entitled to speak in that manner. This move also has gendered and generational implications, especially in a parliamentary culture where hierarchy and seniority carry significant interactional weight. In the public sphere, the exchange constructs Akpoti-Uduaghan as a morally assertive challenger and Goje as a defender of institutional seniority and order.

DATA V: Senator Akpoti-Uduaghan: You cannot silence my voice. Nigerians deserve to hear this.
Senator Akpabio: We are not in a nightclub.

Akpoti-Uduaghan's utterance frames the interaction as a struggle over voice, visibility, and democratic participation. The phrase "You cannot silence my voice" is more than a complaint about interruption. It metaphorically recasts procedural restriction as suppression. The verb "silence" carries strong implications of erasure, exclusion, and denial of expression. In this way, the speaker transforms a procedural disagreement into a symbolic struggle over representation and legitimacy. The second sentence, "Nigerians deserve to hear this," broadens the audience and intensifies the claim. Rather than positioning the matter as a private exchange within the chamber, the speaker invokes an external public entitled to access the suppressed truth or perspective. This is a strong act of mediated audience orientation. It aligns the speaker with national public interest and positions the restriction of her speech as a denial not only of her voice but of the public's right to know. This enhances her positive face before an external audience by projecting courage, transparency, and resistance. Akpabio's reply, "We are not in a nightclub," is a metaphorical rebuke that carries both evaluative and regulatory force. The metaphor works by constructing a contrast between the expected decorum of parliamentary proceedings and the imagined disorderliness of a nightclub. The utterance therefore does not simply criticise the content of the speaker's contribution; it recontextualises her behaviour as noisy, unruly, and inappropriate. In Culpeper's terms, this is bald-on-record impoliteness because the criticism is explicit, vivid, and minimally mitigated.

From a pragmatic perspective, the metaphor also performs institutional boundary-setting. It defines what the chamber is not to reinforce what it should be. This is Goffmanian facework at the institutional level. The Senate President protects the face of the institution by rejecting a code of conduct that he frames as incompatible with legislative seriousness. At the same time, the utterance undermines Akpoti-Uduaghan's positive face by presenting her as misaligned with parliamentary expectations. Because the metaphor is memorable and media-friendly, it also has strong public resonance, further illustrating how conflict talks in the Senate are shaped by the possibility of circulation beyond the chamber.

DATA VI: Senator Ibrahim: Economic policy cannot be reduced to street logic.
Senator Oshiomhole: Any arithmetic that ignores the poor is wicked arithmetic.

This exchange shows that conflict in parliamentary discourse often involves not only disagreement over policy but contest over what counts as legitimate reasoning. Ibrahim's statement attacks the intellectual standing of opposing arguments through the dismissive phrase "street logic." This expression carries strong evaluative connotations. It associates the opposing position with informality, crudity, and unsophisticated reasoning, as opposed to expert, technical, or disciplined thought. In Culpeper's framework, this is positive impoliteness because it undermines the addressee's competence and credibility.

The modal construction “cannot be reduced” is also significant. It does not merely suggest that street logic is insufficient; it frames such reduction as fundamentally illegitimate. This gives the statement high epistemic force. The speaker presents himself as the custodian of serious economic reasoning and positions opponents as failing to meet that standard.

Oshiomhole’s response does not accept the frame of technical superiority. Instead, he introduces a counter-frame through the phrase “wicked arithmetic.” This is a striking expression because it moralises calculation. The noun “arithmetic” belongs to the domain of numbers, logic, and technical evaluation, but the adjective “wicked” pulls it into the ethical domain. By doing so, Oshiomhole rejects the separation of economic reasoning from social consequence. He implies that a purely technical argument which ignores suffering is not neutral but morally compromised.

This is again positive impoliteness, though of a different kind. Instead of attacking intellectual weakness, it attacks moral deficiency. The exchange therefore reveals a struggle between two forms of authority: technocratic expertise and moral accountability. In Goffmanian terms, both speakers are engaged in face negotiation over what kind of public identity is most legitimate in the debate. Ibrahim seeks the face of rational economic expertise, while Oshiomhole seeks the face of morally grounded representation. This makes the interaction especially significant for your paper, because it shows how conflict talks produce not only disagreement but identity construction through competing discursive frames.

DATA VII: Senator Adeyemi: The South-South should stop crying.

Senator Dickson: It is not crying; it is justice. When land bleeds, equity must follow.

Adeyemi’s utterance trivialises regional grievance through the verb “crying.” This lexical choice is highly significant because it frames a political and economic complaint as emotional excess rather than legitimate grievance. The effect is infantilising and dismissive. In pragmatic terms, it delegitimises the South-South’s claim by recasting it as overreaction. This is a strong act of positive impoliteness directed not only at an individual interlocutor but at a regional identity position. The prescriptive structure “should stop” adds further force. It does not merely describe the grievance as exaggerated; it tells the region to cease expressing it. This is both evaluative and regulatory. It implies that continued complaint is inappropriate, excessive, or politically manipulative.

Dickson’s response immediately rejects the frame. The contrastive structure “It is not crying; it is justice” is rhetorically powerful because it performs direct redefinition. The issue is taken out of the emotional register and relocated into the moral register. The noun “justice” invokes fairness, redress, and ethical obligation, thereby restoring legitimacy to the grievance. The metaphor “When land bleeds” intensifies this moral framing. It evokes exploitation, injury, and sacrifice, particularly in relation to environmental and resource politics in the Niger Delta. The land is personified as a suffering body, which heightens the emotional and ethical force of the argument. The modal “must” in “equity must follow” expresses obligation rather than preference, presenting redistribution or redress as morally necessary. From a Goffmanian

perspective, Dickson's response performs face restoration for the South-South by reclaiming grievance as morally grounded and politically valid. It also constructs him as a representative voice of regional justice, thereby strengthening his public political identity.

DATA VIII: Senator Aliero: How do we preach accountability when committees cannot account?

Senator Akpabio: Avoid casting shadows on this chamber.

Aliero's rhetorical question functions as an indirect accusation. The phrase "How do we preach accountability" implies contradiction between institutional rhetoric and practice. The pronoun "we" collectivises the issue, implicating the entire chamber rather than one actor alone. This makes the utterance particularly strong, because it threatens the institutional face of the Senate as a body that claims to supervise accountability in the wider political system. The clause "when committees cannot account" intensifies the accusation by turning the Senate's oversight function back upon itself. It suggests that those who demand accountability from others may be failing to embody it themselves. The rhetorical question structure gives the utterance an appearance of inquiry, but pragmatically it is accusatory rather than information-seeking.

Akpabio's response is an act of discursive control. The imperative "Avoid" is clearly restrictive and therefore an instance of negative impoliteness. The metaphor "casting shadows" reframes criticism as reputational damage. Rather than engaging with whether committees in fact cannot account, the response focuses on the danger of the utterance itself to the image of the chamber. This is a strong example of institutional facework in Goffman's sense. The Senate President seeks to protect the chamber's public legitimacy by containing speech that threatens its credibility. The exchange shows how procedural authority often works by shifting the issue from substance to form. The criticism is not rebutted through counter-evidence; it is managed as a problem of speech boundaries. That is one of the defining features of conflict talks in legislative settings.

DATA IX: Senator Oshiomhole: Distinguished Senator, your interpretation is certainly interesting.

Senator Ibrahim: At least it is based on facts.

This exchange demonstrates mock politeness as a subtle but sharp form of institutional conflict. Oshiomhole's utterance begins with the ritual address "Distinguished Senator," which preserves formal decorum. However, the adjective "interesting" is contextually sarcastic. In ordinary conversation, it could signal curiosity or appreciation, but in an adversarial parliamentary context it often carries the implicature that the interpretation is questionable, strange, or flawed. This divergence between literal and intended meaning is what makes the utterance mock politeness rather than straightforward praise.

The adverb "certainly" strengthens the sarcastic tone. It gives the utterance a polished surface while deepening its rhetorical bite. In Culpeper's terms, this is mock politeness because the expression of respect is not sincere but is used to communicate criticism. The utterance threatens positive face by undermining the intellectual credibility

of the addressee while allowing the speaker to remain formally within parliamentary norms. Ibrahim's response, "At least it is based on facts," escalates the exchange through contrastive implication. The phrase "at least" suggests a comparison, and the unstated implication is that the previous speaker's interpretation lacks factual grounding. This is a strategic counterattack on credibility. It retains a measured form, but its force is unmistakable. The exchange shows how sarcasm and counter-sarcasm allow senators to attack without abandoning decorum, making mock politeness one of the most effective conflict strategies in a heavily regulated institution.

DATA X: Senator Musa: This policy will worsen the suffering of Nigerians.
Senator Oshiomhole: That is simply incorrect.

This exchange illustrates how conflict can be intensified through brevity and omission rather than elaborate insult. Musa's utterance frames the policy in moral and social terms through the phrase "worsen the suffering of Nigerians." The noun "suffering" invokes hardship, vulnerability, and public consequence, thereby giving the statement strong emotional and ethical force. It aligns the speaker with public concern and positions the policy as socially harmful. Oshiomhole's reply is striking in its abruptness. The sentence "That is simply incorrect" contains no honorific, no mitigating phrase, and no softening device. In a setting where disagreement is often introduced through formal courtesy, this absence is itself meaningful. It is an instance of withholding politeness. The adverb "simply" intensifies the dismissal by suggesting that the error is plain, obvious, and not worthy of extended consideration. Pragmatically, the response threatens Musa's positive face by denying the legitimacy of his argument without engaging its reasoning in any depth.

From a Goffmanian perspective, the utterance performs face threat through denial of interactional recognition. It treats the claim as unworthy of elaboration and thereby symbolically downgrades the speaker's contribution. The exchange demonstrates that in parliamentary discourse, even minimal language can carry significant antagonistic force. Not all conflict requires elaborate rhetorical display. Sometimes a blunt, unadorned dismissal is enough to signal impatience, superiority, and disagreement.

Conclusion

This study has demonstrated that conflict talks in Nigeria's 10th Senate function as structured and meaningful aspects of parliamentary interaction rather than as simple breakdowns of decorum. Through the integrated application of Goffman's (1967) concept of facework, Brown and Levinson's (1987) politeness theory, and Culpeper's (1996, 2011) impoliteness framework, the analysis has shown that senators strategically deploy linguistic resources to manage interpersonal relations, contest authority, and negotiate institutional legitimacy. The study establishes that politeness and impoliteness are not oppositional or mutually exclusive phenomena in Senate discourse. Rather, they operate as complementary communicative strategies. Politeness helps sustain procedural order, institutional respect, and recognisable parliamentary form, while impoliteness enables contestation, critique, ideological positioning, and resistance. Their coexistence reflects the complex nature of democratic discourse, where institutional civility and adversarial

engagement must function together. The study also highlights the significance of mediatization in shaping contemporary parliamentary communication. Senate debates are increasingly oriented towards audiences beyond the chamber, and this expands the communicative function of conflict talks. In such settings, utterances do not merely express disagreement. They also construct their personal identity. Senators speak not only as participants in legislative debate but also as public actors whose linguistic choices contribute to how they are perceived by constituents, political allies, opponents, and the wider Nigerian public. Overall, this paper contributes to pragmatics and political discourse studies by demonstrating that conflict talks are central to the functioning of parliamentary interaction in Nigeria's 10th Senate. They are among the key mechanisms through which power, identity, accountability, and legitimacy are negotiated in a highly visible democratic institution.

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